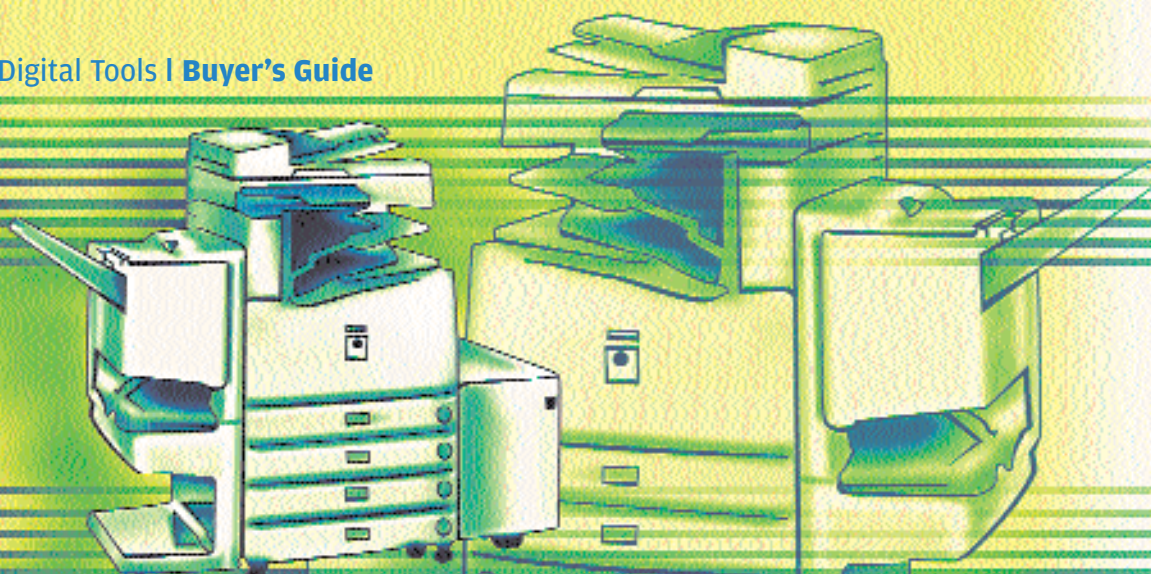




MULTIFUNCTIONAL COPIERS

The multifunction copier is an MFD based on a copier-based engine. Being copier-based implies that the cost is much higher than that of a printer-based MFD, but the duty cycles are much higher. The multifunction copier is very rugged, and its cost per page is also much lower compared to that of its printer-based cousins. It is also capable of standalone operation.

The multifunction copier usually caters to corporate users such as enterprises, DTPs and the legal industry, where high-volume output is the need.

Questions to ask the dealer

What is the maximum possible scan and print size?

Look for a product that can scan and print documents large enough for your particular needs.

What are the toner and printer duty cycles?

The printer duty cycle is the number of pages the printer can print in a month at default quality settings. The toner duty cycle is the total number of pages the toner can print. Needless to say, look for a higher number.

What are the additional upgrades

available with multifunctional copiers?

Some of the upgrades available are as below:

Puncher: This enables punching of holes in the print medium after printing. This is useful for binding purposes.

Binder: Sheets of papers can be transformed into booklets using this feature.

Duplex Automatic Document Feeder:

Most MFDs come with an ADF, but a duplex ADF can also be added to some MFDs.

Stacker: If you need additional output capabilities, a stacker augments the output paper capacity.

The above features and more are available on some models, but these can be added any time after purchase to most of the models that don't come with these frills.

What is the warranty offered?

Given the heavy-duty usage of this class of products, warranty is of the utmost importance. Every player in this arena offers on-site warranties. Therefore, what you need to for is how good the service network is, in addition to, of course, how many years the warranty is for.

Usage tips

Power users or high-production departments should be put on a separate network segment to minimise LAN congestion in case of networked devices.

Use the software tools provided with the device to manage printer resources

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across the network and reduce support time and maintenance expenditure.

Certain devices provide clustering capabilities, where the print job is spanned across multiple devices, thus increasing the page output per minute.

The Future

Quite a few innovations are underway in the field of multifunction copiers. Some already have features similar to computers, such as a CPU, RAM and hard drive.

Upcoming technologies include Canon's Multifunctional Embedded Application Platform (MEAP) J2ME Java-based technology, which enables customised business applications to be created and installed on the device. These can be controlled via the MFD's user interface. As an example, using an MEAP application installed on a device, a bank could train the device to differentiate between a home loan, personal loan and credit card application, and the device could electronically route scanned paperwork for processing. ■

Points To Ponder

Why should I buy a multifunction copier in the first place?

Opt for an multifunction copier when:

- You wish to save office space, and/or want to replace your copier with a better solution
- Your print volumes are very high
- You want to be able to purchase add-ons as your needs grow
- You require advanced features such as advanced document management
- You wish to eliminate the time lost in moving documents from one device to another—such as printer to fax

What are the advantages of a copier-based MFD?

Copier-based MFDs have a separate toner and drum. This means that when one of them is exhausted, you need to replace only that. This reduces the overall running cost as compared to printer-based solutions, where the toner—which is not separable from the drum—has to be discarded and replaced when it's exhausted.

In addition to this, the printer duty cycle is very high, and print speeds are also very high.